

“A **violent** response is in order ... we will **act** and we will act **quickly.**”

VICE PRESIDENT NELSON ROCKEFELLER DURING A NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL MEETING, MAY 12, 1975



Retaking the *Mayaguez*

When the USS *Harold E. Holt* (left) approached the SS *Mayaguez* to recapture the ship, the crew found it already abandoned. Marines from *Holt* conducted the first hostile ship-to-ship boarding by the US Navy since 1826.

Developing debacle

Alarmed at the strength of the US response to the incident, the local Khmer Rouge conveyed the captors' readiness to end the affair to the captain of the *Mayaguez*. As a result, the Khmer Rouge released the *Mayaguez* crew not long after the US assault on Koh Tang started, and three hours later they were delivered to the USS *Henry B. Wilson* by a Thai fishing boat.

Upon hearing of the release of the American sailors, President Ford ordered the suspension of the invasion and a withdrawal of US forces. However, aborting the assault mid-battle was not possible.

The initial landing had been costly. Several troop-carrying helicopters were hit and destroyed, including one that was blown up in the air, killing 13 servicemen and injuring the pilot. The rescue of the US forces proved to be just as dangerous as the assault. In a 14-